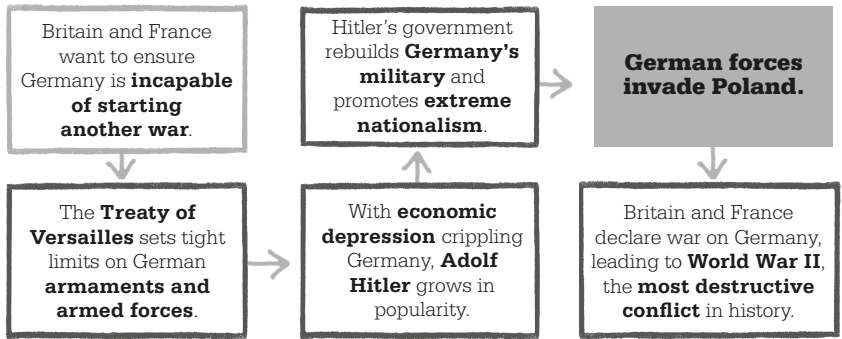




The rise of the Nazi Party

Although World War II was triggered by Hitler's invasion of Poland, its origins can be traced back to Germany's defeat in World War I and the demand for reparation payments. The defeated nations lost land and prestige, causing deep resentment. Germany was forced to return Alsace and Lorraine to France, and all of its overseas colonies were annexed by the Allies.

Germany's Weimar Republic began its economic recovery in the 1920s, but it could not survive the blow that was inflicted by the US economic crash of 1929. This financial crisis aided the rise of the National Socialist (Nazi) Party, led by Hitler, who promised the German people he would make the nation great again.

Hitler had fought in World War I, and the experience of trench warfare, the shock of defeat, and the terms of the Versailles Treaty were to influence the rest of his life. He developed extremist views based on

far-right nationalism; and by the time he became chancellor of Germany's coalition government in 1933, and dictator of the country the next year, he ruthlessly pursued his policies of nationalism, anti-Semitism, and anti-communism.

Hitler's *Lebensraum*

Under this creed, Hitler embarked on an ambitious foreign policy. In 1935, openly going against the terms of the Versailles Treaty, he began a massive program of rearmament. In 1936, he occupied the demilitarized Rhineland, but none of the major powers intervened. In March 1938, Hitler annexed Austria to Germany, before setting his sights on the German-speaking part of Czechoslovakia, the Sudetenland. British and French politicians wanted to avoid a repeat of the horrors of World War I and felt that the Sudetenland was not worth fighting for. In the Munich Agreement of September 29, 1938, the Sudetenland was handed to Hitler in exchange for his promise to end his land-grabs. British prime minister Neville Chamberlain declared that he had secured "peace for our time," only for the Nazis to invade the remainder of Czechoslovakia in March 1939.

Fascism in Europe

Italy's Fascist dictator Benito Mussolini also had aspirations for foreign glory. In October 1935, he invaded Abyssinia (Ethiopia) in retaliation for the defeat the Italians had suffered there in 1896. By May 1936, Mussolini had conquered the country, facing no opposition from the Western powers. »



Adolf Hitler watches a victory parade in Warsaw following the invasion of Poland. He and Soviet leader Joseph Stalin agreed to the invasion and division of the country.